

THE BUCK \$TARTS HERE

Grant Writing Masterclass

Module 10 — Attachments, Session 2: Community Standing & Full Audit

Student Course Companion

Name: _____ Organization: _____

Team / Cohort (if applicable): _____

This workbook is your companion to Module 10. We complete the attachments package with four categories that document your community standing — and close with a full audit of all eight categories across both sessions. Team prompts appear in green throughout.

Section 1 — Key Terms & Concepts

These are the core concepts for Module 10. Each one maps to a specific attachment category.

Annual Report	A document telling your organization's story through financial transparency, program accomplishments, and human impact. Contains four elements: expenditure breakdown, income sources, program outcomes, and one participant story.
Annual Report Substitute	If no formal annual report exists: a current program brochure, a recent newsletter, a one-page impact summary, or relevant news coverage. One polished, relevant piece is more effective than a stack of outdated materials.
IRS Determination Letter	The official document from the IRS confirming your organization's 501(c)(3) public charity status under section 509(a). Non-negotiable for virtually every foundation grant. Must be the most recent copy on file.
501(c)(3)	The section of the Internal Revenue Code that grants tax-exempt status to nonprofit organizations. The determination letter confirms this status.

THE BUCK \$TARTS HERE

Section 509(a)	The IRS classification confirming that your organization is a public charity, not a private foundation. Important because private foundations face restrictions on grant making to other private foundations.
Fiscal Sponsorship	An arrangement in which an established 501(c)(3) organization receives and administers grant funds on behalf of an emerging organization that does not yet have its own tax-exempt status.
List of Major Contributors	A roster of funders, donors, and supporters who made significant financial investments in your organization during the most recently completed fiscal year. Organized largest to smallest. Must be accurate and current.
Volunteer Hours (Dollar Value)	The calculable fair market value of volunteer time. The Independent Sector publishes an annual national rate, currently approximately \$31 per hour. Used to quantify community investment in your program.
In-Kind Contribution	A non-cash resource contributed to your program at no charge: space, supplies, equipment, professional services, food, printing. Valued at fair market rate — what it would cost if purchased on the open market.
Independent Sector Rate	The annual estimate of the fair market value of volunteer time published by Independent Sector, a national nonprofit leadership organization. Currently approximately \$31 per hour nationally; varies by state and skill level.
Full Attachments Audit	A systematic review of all eight attachment categories to assess whether each document exists, is current, and represents the organization at its best. Conducted before every major submission cycle.
Grant Readiness	The state of having a complete, current, organized attachments package maintained year-round — not assembled in a rush before a deadline. The hallmark of organizations that get funded consistently.

Section 2 — Annotated Example

Read the annotated examples below. The right column explains what each element communicates to a funder. Identify which elements your organization currently has in place and which need attention.

THE BUCK \$TARTS HERE

Sample: Volunteer & In-Kind Summary Statement and Contributors List Context

ATTACHMENT CONTENT	WHAT IT COMMUNICATES
[ANNUAL REPORT — FOUR REQUIRED ELEMENTS] 1. <i>Expenditure Breakdown: 74% program services / 18% administration / 8% fundraising [pie chart]</i> 2. <i>Income Sources: Hartwell Foundation 28% / County Contract 34% / Individual Donors 19% / Earned Revenue 12% / In-Kind 7% [bar chart]</i> 3. <i>Program Highlights: Served 1,240 participants across 6 sites. 88% completed the program. 79% secured employment within 90 days.</i> 4. <i>Participant Story: “When Marcus came to us, he had been unemployed for 14 months. He’d sent out 40 applications without a callback. Six months after completing our program, he is a floor supervisor at [Company] earning \$22/hour.”</i>	→ 74% to programs = funder priorities visible at a glance → Five income sources = diversified, resilient funding base → Specific numbers (1,240 / 88% / 79%) = credibility through specificity → One real story with a name, a timeline, and a wage = human proof of impact
[VOLUNTEER & IN-KIND SUMMARY STATEMENT] <i>In the most recently completed fiscal year, Community Works engaged 186 volunteers who contributed 6,820 hours of service valued at \$211,420 (at the Independent Sector national rate of \$31/hour). This includes 3,100 hours of direct client service, 1,240 hours of licensed professional services (legal aid, mental health counseling, and medical screenings), and 2,480 hours of skilled technical support (web development, facility maintenance, and grant writing assistance). In-kind contributions from partner organizations include office and meeting space (\$18,000 annual rental value), printed materials (\$4,200), and donated food for program events (\$3,600). Total volunteer and in-kind community investment: \$237,220.</i>	→ Total hours + dollar value make community investment concrete (\$211,420) → Three categories of volunteer service tell different stories about the organization’s reach → In-kind contributions valued at fair market rate — not vague or unquantified → Grand total (\$237,220) makes the argument: your community has already voted for this work
[MAJOR CONTRIBUTORS LIST — FORMAT EXAMPLE] <i>Hartwell Family Foundation — \$80,000 (General Operating Support)</i> <i>County Department of Workforce Development — \$65,000 (Career Pathways Program)</i> <i>Meridian Corporate Foundation — \$30,000 (Youth Employment Initiative)</i> <i>Anonymous Individual Donor — \$15,000</i>	→ Organized largest to smallest — most credible names first → Each entry names the amount and the purpose — not just the funder → Fiscal year stated explicitly — no ambiguity about currency → Foundation + government + corporate + individual = diversified base that signals stability

Module 10

THE BUCK \$TARTS HERE

All contributions reflect FY2023–2024 (July 1, 2023 – June 30, 2024)

☐ **Team:** As a group: does your organization currently track volunteer hours by type? If not, assign someone to set up a monthly tracking spreadsheet by your next board meeting. This data is essential for quantifying community investment.

Section 3 — Before & After Comparisons

Study each pair. The weak version shows what most organizations submit. The strong version shows what builds funder confidence. Answer the reflection question after each pair.

Comparison 1 — Volunteer and In-Kind Description

☐ **Weak**

We have many dedicated volunteers who support our work throughout the year. Community members and local businesses also donate supplies and other resources that help us serve our clients.

☐ **Strong**

In the most recently completed fiscal year, we engaged 143 volunteers who contributed 4,820 hours of service valued at \$149,420 (Independent Sector national rate, \$31/hour). This includes 2,100 hours of direct mentorship, 800 hours of pro bono legal and financial counseling, and 1,920 hours of skilled technical support. In-kind contributions include donated office space (\$14,400 annual value), printing (\$2,800), and food for program events (\$1,600). Total community investment: \$168,220.

☐ **What makes the strong version persuasive in a way the weak version cannot be? What would a funder think when they read “we have many dedicated volunteers” versus a quantified statement with a dollar total?**

THE BUCK \$TARTS HERE

☐ **Team discussion:** Start a volunteer tracking log today if you don't have one. Assign a team member to pull last year's volunteer data from whatever records exist and calculate a starting dollar value. Even a rough estimate is more compelling than nothing.

Comparison 2 — Annual Report Substitute (When No Formal Report Exists)

☐ **Weak**

We do not currently have an annual report. We are a growing organization and are working to put together materials that describe our work.

☐ **Strong**

In lieu of a formal annual report, we have included our most recent program impact summary (attached). This two-page document includes our mission statement, our FY2024 outcome data (served 387 participants, 83% completion rate, 71% employment placement), a brief financial snapshot showing four revenue sources, and a participant testimonial from a program graduate. We are currently developing a full annual report for FY2025, which we anticipate completing by October.

☐ **What does the strong substitute do that the weak response cannot? How does naming a timeline for a future annual report help rather than hurt?**

☐ **Team discussion:** What does your organization currently have that could serve as an annual report substitute? Identify the single most current and compelling piece and confirm it includes outcome data. Assign someone to create a simple two-page impact summary if nothing adequate exists.

Comparison 3 — Major Contributors List (New Organization)

☐ **Weak**

We are a newer organization and are still building our donor base. We have had some support from local community members and businesses but do not yet have a formal contributors list.

☐ **Strong**

Community Pathways was established in 2022 and is in its third year of operation. Our current contributors list reflects FY2023–2024: City of [City] Community Development Block Grant — \$18,000; [Local Foundation] — \$10,000; individual donors (12 contributors) — \$6,400. Total: \$34,400. We are actively cultivating three additional foundation relationships and project our contributor base to grow significantly in

THE BUCK \$TARTS HERE

FY2025. A detailed donor cultivation plan is available upon request.

- ☐ How does the strong version for a newer organization turn a perceived weakness (short list) into a credibility asset?

☐ **Team discussion:** *If your contributors list is shorter than you would like, draft a two-sentence acknowledgment that presents it honestly while signaling forward momentum. Never inflate. Transparency paired with a clear growth plan is always stronger than false confidence.*

Section 4 — Your Attachments Builder: E through H

Complete each part below. By the end of this section you will have a clear, quantified picture of your organization's community standing and know exactly what still needs to be developed.

Part E — Annual Report

- ☐ Does your organization produce a formal annual report? ☐ Yes (year: _____) ☐ No ☐ In progress

If YES, confirm it contains all four required elements:

- ☐ Expenditure breakdown (visual preferred) ☐ Income sources breakdown (visual preferred)
- ☐ Program outcomes with specific data ☐ At least one participant story
- ☐ **If NO: What is your best available substitute? (brochure, newsletter, impact summary, news article)**

THE BUCK \$TARTS HERE

☐ If you are building a two-page annual report from scratch, draft the three to five key outcomes you would include (specific numbers only):

☐ Draft your one participant story in 3–4 sentences. Use a first name only and specific details:

☐ **Team discussion:** Share your participant stories as a group. Choose the one that most powerfully illustrates the change your program creates. Assign someone to finalize and format it before the next submission.

Part F — IRS Determination Letter

☐ Does your organization have a current IRS Determination Letter on file? ☐ Yes ☐ No ☐
We have a letter but it may be outdated

☐ If YES: What is the date on the letter? Has your organization undergone a name change, merger, or major restructuring since it was issued?

☐ If NO or outdated: What is your plan? (Request updated determination from IRS / Obtain legal opinion / Explore fiscal sponsorship) — Name the action and the person responsible:

☐ **Tip:** Keep a legible, current scan of your IRS Determination Letter in your grant files folder at all times. This is a non-negotiable document for virtually every foundation grant. Never scramble to find it the day before a deadline.

☐ **Team:** Assign someone right now to locate your IRS Determination Letter, confirm it is current, scan it to a shared drive, and confirm where it is stored. This takes 15 minutes and should never be an emergency.

THE BUCK \$TARTS HERE

Part G — List of Major Contributors

Complete the contributors table below. List all significant funders and donors from your most recently completed fiscal year, organized largest to smallest.

Fiscal Year Covered: _____

Contributor Name	Type (Foundation / Govt / Corporate / Individual)	Amount (\$)	Fiscal Year	Grant / Donation Purpose

☐ Total contributions from your list: \$_____ Number of unique contributors: _____

☐ If your list is shorter than you would like, write a two-sentence honest acknowledgment for your narrative that presents your current base accurately and signals growth trajectory:

☐ **Tip:** Every amount on this list must be accurate and verifiable. Program officers in the philanthropic community often know each other. If a funder you listed is contacted by a new funder and the figures don't match, that is a trust problem that is very hard to recover from.

Part H — Volunteer and In-Kind Contributions

Complete both tables below. Use the Independent Sector rate of \$31/hour for volunteer time unless you have a state-specific rate that is higher.

Module 10

THE BUCK \$TARTS HERE

VOLUNTEER HOURS TABLE

Volunteer Contribution Type	# of Volunteers	Total Hours	Estimated Value (hrs × \$31)
Direct Service (mentoring, tutoring, case support, etc.)			
Licensed Professional Services (legal, medical, accounting, counseling)			
Skilled Technical Support (web, construction, grant writing, etc.)			
Administrative / General Support			
TOTAL VOLUNTEER HOURS / VALUE			

IN-KIND CONTRIBUTIONS TABLE

Contributing Organization / Individual	Type of Contribution	Fair Market Value (\$)	How Value Was Calculated
TOTAL IN-KIND VALUE			

☐ Combined total (volunteer value + in-kind value): \$_____

☐ Write a 3–4 sentence summary statement presenting your volunteer and in-kind totals for use in your proposal narrative:

THE BUCK \$TARTS HERE

□ **Team discussion:** Review your totals as a group. Does the combined number surprise you? This is community investment that was always there — it just was not being made visible. Assign someone to start a monthly tracking spreadsheet so this number grows every year.

★**Example — Volunteer and in-kind summary in proposal language:**

In the most recently completed fiscal year, [Organization] engaged [#] volunteers who contributed [#] hours of service valued at \$[amount] at the Independent Sector national rate of \$31 per hour. This includes [#] hours of direct service, [#] hours of licensed professional services, and [#] hours of skilled technical support. In-kind contributions from community partners totaled \$[amount], including [space / supplies / services]. Combined, the community's volunteer and in-kind investment in this work reached \$[total] — evidence that our neighbors have already chosen to stand behind this program with their time and resources.

Full Attachments Audit — All Eight Categories

Complete this audit before every major grant submission. For each category, confirm: (1) you have it, (2) it is current, and (3) it represents your organization at its best. Unchecked boxes are action items.

✓	Cat.	Document	Ready If...	Have It?	Current?
□	A	Board of Directors List	<i>Every member has position, occupation, and affiliations listed</i>	□ Yes □ No	□ Yes □ No
□	B	Anti-Discrimination Statement	<i>Board-adopted, recorded in minutes, current leadership and name</i>	□ Yes □ No	□ Yes □ No
□	C	Key Staff List	<i>Names, titles, credentials, experience; vacancies with qualifications</i>	□ Yes □ No	□ Yes □ No
□	D	Financials	<i>Year-end statements + org budget + program budget (if project grant)</i>	□ Yes □ No	□ Yes □ No
□	E	Annual Report (or	<i>4 elements: expenditure</i>	□ Yes □ No	□ Yes □ No

THE BUCK \$TARTS HERE

		substitute)	breakdown, income sources, outcomes, story		
☐	F	IRS Determination Letter	Most recent, 501(c)(3) public charity under 509(a), legible copy	☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No
☐	G	List of Major Contributors	Current FY, organized largest to smallest, accurate amounts	☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No
☐	H	Volunteer & In-Kind Contributions	Hours by type + dollar value + in-kind at fair market value	☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No

☐ **Team:** Complete this audit as a group at least once per grant cycle. Assign each action item to a specific team member with a deadline. The organizations that get funded consistently are the ones whose attachments file is always ready — never assembled in a panic.

Section 5 — Module 10 Self-Audit Checklist

Check every box you can honestly say is true. Unchecked boxes are action items before your next submission.

E — Annual Report

- ☐ I have a current annual report, program brochure, impact summary, or newsletter I can attach.
- ☐ My substitute document includes specific outcome data — not vague descriptions of my work.
- ☐ It includes or I can describe at least one specific participant story with real details.
- ☐ If I don't have an annual report, I have a plan and a timeline to create one.

F — IRS Determination Letter

- ☐ My IRS Determination Letter is current, legible, and on file in my grant documents folder.
- ☐ The letter confirms 501(c)(3) status under section 509(a) — public charity classification.
- ☐ The letter accurately reflects my organization's current legal name and structure.
- ☐ If my situation has changed since the original letter, I have a plan to address it.

THE BUCK \$TARTS HERE

G — List of Major Contributors

- ☐ My contributors list reflects the most recently completed fiscal year — not prior years.
- ☐ All amounts are accurate and verifiable.
- ☐ The list is organized largest to smallest with funder names, amounts, and fiscal year noted.
- ☐ I have not inflated, rounded up, or included outdated contributions as current.

H — Volunteer and In-Kind Contributions

- ☐ I have calculated the dollar value of volunteer hours using the current Independent Sector rate.
- ☐ I have broken volunteer hours into at least two categories (direct service, professional services, technical support).
- ☐ I have documented all in-kind contributions at fair market value.
- ☐ I have a combined total that I will make visible in my proposal narrative.
- ☐ I have a system (or a plan to create one) for tracking volunteer hours and in-kind contributions monthly.

Full Package Readiness

- ☐ All eight attachment categories have been reviewed: A through H.
- ☐ Every document is current — reflecting the most recent fiscal year, leadership, and organizational information.
- ☐ My attachments file is organized and can be assembled for a submission within 24 hours.
- ☐ I am not scrambling for any of these documents at deadline time.

My action items before my next submission:

THE BUCK \$TARTS HERE

□ **Team:** Assign each action item a team member and a deadline. Write names next to each item above before leaving this session. Your attachments file should be fully current and organized before your next deadline.

*“A proposal without strong attachments
is like a résumé without references.
Your narrative gets you in the room.
Your attachments close the deal.”*

— Grant Writing Masterclass, Module 10